Albert Einstein.

On Wednesday, May 25, 1949, David Bohm appeared before the House Un-American Activities Committee (HUAC). Sitting opposite six congressmen—including one Representative Richard M. Nixon—and another half-dozen congressional staffers, Bohm was asked about the extent of his association with the Communist Party. “I can’t answer that question,” he replied, “because it might tend to incriminate and degrade me, and, also, I think it infringes on my rights as guaranteed by the First Amendment.” The committee asked him to repeat himself, then asked him dozens more questions, asking Bohm to implicate several of his former colleagues and friends from his time at Berkeley, including Joe Weinberg. Bohm refused. Then he went home and didn’t think much more about it for over a year. “Apparently the whole issue was dying away,” he recalled later.

Bohm had other troubles on his mind. He was assembling his quantum physics course materials into a textbook, taking great care to explain and defend the Copenhagen interpretation. But doubts had crept in, and, as the book neared completion in the summer of 1950, those doubts grew. “When I finished the book, I wasn’t quite satisfied that I really understood it,” Bohm said. Then, on December 4, 1950, a US marshal walked into Bohm’s office and arrested him.

Bohm was taken down to a federal courthouse in Trenton and indicted for contempt of Congress, for refusing to testify to HUAC. Loewy, along with Bohm’s student Sam Schweber, drove to Trenton and bailed Bohm out. When they returned to Princeton, they found that Harold Dodds, the president of the university, had already suspended Bohm from research and teaching duties, and forbidden him to set foot on campus. Bohm was blacklisted.